THE STOP-LOSS STRATEGY

Protect the Conversation Before It Becomes Destructive

WHAT IS A "STOP-LOSS"?

In investing, a *stop-loss* is a **pre-decided exit point** to prevent deeper loss.

➡️ *Example:*
If you invest $100 and set a stop-loss at $90, you exit before losing more.

WHAT THIS MEANS IN CONFLICT

A **Stop-Loss in communication** is a **pre-agreed boundary** where both people:

- Recognize when emotions are escalating
- Pause the conversation *before damage is done*
- Step away to reset
- Return later to finish safely

You're not quitting the conversation… you're protecting it.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most conflict doesn't break relationships…**How we handle it does.**

Without a stop-loss:

- Words get sharper
- Defensiveness increases
- Respect drops
- Damage multiplies

With a stop-loss:

- You preserve safety
- You protect trust
- You stay aligned with your goal: **resolution, not winning**

WHAT CAUSES STOP-LOSS TRIGGERS?

(Where escalation actually begins)

It usually starts with something small…

A comment
A tone
A facial expression
A misunderstanding

That moment creates a "pinch"

- You feel it internally
- It catches you off guard
- It hits something deeper (past hurt, insecurity, fear)

Before you realize it…

You're **"in your feelings"**
Emotions take over
Behavior follows emotion (not wisdom)

Proverbs 4:23 (NIV)
"Above all else, guard your heart, for everything you do flows from it."

James 1:14–15 (NIV)
"Each person is tempted when they are dragged away by their own desire… then desire… gives birth to sin."

Translation:
The "pinch" → leads to internal reaction → leads to external behavior

KEY INSIGHT

You don't go from calm to conflict instantly. You go from "pinch" → to emotion → to reaction.

The stop-loss is designed to **interrupt that chain**.

STOP-LOSS TRIGGERS

(When to EXIT the conversation)

The moment **ANY of these show up**, you call a stop-loss:

Emotional Escalation

- Raised voices / yelling
- Sarcasm or harsh tone
- Interrupting repeatedly
- Talking faster / reacting instead of listening

Loss of Control

- You feel overwhelmed or flooded
- You're no longer thinking clearly
- You're preparing your defense instead of listening
- You "have to win" the conversation

Disrespect Signals

- Name-calling or criticism
- Bringing up the past to attack
- Blame-shifting
- Dismissiveness ("whatever," eye-rolling, shutting down)

Breakdown of Process

- SCIP is gone (you're reacting, not processing)
- L.U.V.E. is gone (no listening, validating, or empathy)
- You're repeating the same point with no progress

HOW TO CALL A STOP-LOSS

This must be **pre-agreed** and **honored immediately**

Simple Script:

- "I'm feeling overwhelmed—I need to call a stop-loss."
- "I want to do this right, but I need a reset."

- “I care about this too much to keep going like this.”

No arguing about it
No chasing
No continuing the discussion

EXIT PROCESS (What to do immediately)

1. Pause the conversation

- Stop talking immediately
- No last word

2. Physically separate

- Different rooms or space
- Reduce stimulation

3. Regulate yourself (SCIP mode)

- Sit down
- Calm down (breathing, prayer)
- Identify what you’re feeling
- Process before reacting

Proverbs 29:11 (NIV)
“Fools give full vent to their rage, but the wise bring calm in the end.”

4. Do NOT rehearse arguments

- No “comebacks”
- No building your case
- Focus on **calm + clarity**, not winning

HOW LONG TO STEP AWAY

Minimum: 20–30 minutes

- Allows your body to calm down physiologically

Recommended: 30–60 minutes

- Full emotional reset

Maximum: 24 hours

- Never leave the issue unresolved beyond a day

Key Rule: Set a **specific return time before leaving**

Examples:

- “Let’s come back to this at 7:00 tonight.”
- “Give me 30 minutes—I’ll come find you.”

HOW TO RETURN

Restart the process (DO NOT pick up mid-conflict)

- Begin again with:
    - Soft opener
    - L.U.V.E. listening
    - Calm tone

Check emotional readiness

- “Are we both in a better place to continue?”

If not → extend the stop-loss (with a new time)

KEY PRINCIPLE

> **A delayed healthy conversation is always better than a destructive one in the moment.**

STOP-LOSS AGREEMENT

Both partners agree:

✔ We will call a stop-loss when needed
✔ We will honor it immediately (no resistance)

✔ We will return at the agreed time
✔ We will restart with the process—not emotion

“Stopping the conversation doesn’t mean failure - It means you care enough to do it right.”